

The Black Mark of Coal
Sept. 10, 2012

"Even in the coal block allocation case, CAG officials explain how it is not a case of 'zero loss' as the government claims. "It is not a question of whether anybody has started mining or not. The issue is that the government has no control over the resource anymore, having given it away arbitrarily," says an official. He explains how CAG calculated the figure of Rs 1.86 lakh crore. CIL controls 81 per cent of all coal mined in the country. "We took an average of CIL coal price and derived the figure of Rs 1.86 lakh crore. It is the most conservative estimate....The intention is not to sensationalise or create scams. It is simply to bring public money to account," the official says."



AP

FACING TRIAL Suresh Kalmadi arrives for a court hearing in New Delhi, Apr. 2011

Nov. 29, 2010, Nov. 21, 2011 (below)





Catalysts of Collapse

A. Raja and Kanimozhi emerged as the most recognisable faces of UPA-era corruption after the 2G spectrum scandal exploded into public view. Raja, as telecom minister, was accused of manipulating policy to underprice licences, causing massive notional losses and favouring select corporates, while Kanimozhi was charged for her alleged role in routing kickbacks through Kalaignar TV. Both were arrested and jailed, turning them into symbols of cronyism and coalition compulsions, even though courts later acquitted them.

estimated a presumptive loss of Rs 1.86 lakh crore. Unlike 2G, where an ally bore the brunt, Coalgate cut uncomfortably close to the PM himself. The narrative of the "clean but weak" PM collapsed under the weight of files, footnotes and contradictions. What bound these scandals together was not merely corruption, but paralysis. Ministers became risk-averse, files stalled, investments dried up and governance froze. Corruption had become a systemic blockage that prevented the state from functioning.

Into this vacuum stepped the street. In 2011, Anna Hazare's anti-corruption movement transformed simmering anger into mass mobilisation. His hunger strike for a Jan Lokpal drew crowds across cities and towns, cutting across class and age. Middle-class India, long resigned to corruption as a fact of life, discovered the language of protest. Parliament was forced to hold a special debate. The government, visibly shaken, conceded ground it had resisted for decades.

The movement was as much moral as political. It framed corruption as theft from the poor and betrayal of democracy. Television amplified its reach, social media organised its supporters, and the judiciary's assertiveness lent it legitimacy. The Lokpal and Lokayuktas Act was finally passed in 2013, a delayed institutional response to an insurgent public mood.

Yet the uprising also exposed the limits of moral politics. The movement fractured, leaders diverged and governance reforms remained uneven. But, by 2014, corruption had become the single most powerful indictment against the ruling UPA, collapsing its credibility and contributing decisively to its electoral annihilation. ■